

GREAT IDEAS GREAT MINDS

Azim H. Premji

The day the Government stops thinking its schools are for the poor, **INDIA WILL TRANSFORM** itself

I believe, there are three key challenges that our nation faces:

- Moving towards social, economic and political equity. The first step here is to ensure that everyone has access to livelihood, education and healthcare.
- Strengthening our multi-cultural heritage, and creating space for diverse worldviews.
- Reducing and reversing human impact on larger ecological processes.

But, I believe, the biggest challenge revolves around a popularly expressed sentiment: "The poor send their children to government schools because they cannot afford private school education." For many of us, the government school classroom is far removed from our everyday lives. Perhaps this is why we are unable to appreciate the pivotal role it plays in Indian society. We need to understand why government schools exist, and indeed what they represent.

An urban upper middle-class parent will have a different set of desires for her child compared to a rural farmer. And this urban parent will be able to back her desire with significantly more money. Since the burgeoning private school system is largely driven by market forces, it is inevitable that these schools will limit themselves to the immediate needs and demands of the communities they serve. There are, of course, several private schools that are motivated by larger social ideals. We have had the privilege of working with many of them as part of Wipro's social initiatives. These schools are beacons; they are the ones that show us what education can be. I am not referring to them, but to a large number of market-driven private schools we see all around us.

One outcome of this is that most such

market-driven private schools operate out of a narrower agenda. Their objectives are usually limited to maximising academic performance in examinations, with some supplemental work in arts and sports. While these objectives might be somewhat important, they fall short of education's larger societal aims. I have even heard people argue that private schools, given that they only reiterate social stratification, hold us back from realising our societal dreams.

The connection between society's aspirations and education becomes clear when we see that the school is a microcosm of larger society. What unfolds within a school today will become the new Indian reality tomorrow. Since our future is mirrored in today's classrooms, society organises education out of two desires. One, it wishes that each new generation will further the limits of human understanding and knowledge. And two, it tries to realise its ideals of equality, liberty, and the dignity of every citizen by constructing this society within its classrooms.

This is what the government school classroom represents; it represents the dreams and aspirations of India in a way that no other school system can. If we wish to transform India, this is where we have to begin. I suppose it is clear why we do grave injustice when we think of government schools as "schools for the poor".

The need to significantly improve the quality of government schools is well recognised, and work is already underway in these areas: making learning more engaging and relevant for children; making classrooms more sensitive to the abilities and inclinations of every child; ensuring adequate teachers, learning material, and school infrastructure; offering greater school autonomy along with accountability and authentic feedback;



PURUSHOTTAM DIWAALKAR

Learning the ropes: Students of a government senior secondary school in Ajmer attending computer classes

Class Apart

A GOVERNMENT SCHOOL CLASSROOM REPRESENTS THE DREAMS AND ASPIRATIONS OF INDIA IN A WAY THAT NO OTHER SCHOOL SYSTEM CAN.